safety certification to the Metro Railway. So everybody agreed to go for broad gauge. That is how broad gauge was decided.' [148]

Change of Gauge

Explaining how Maharashtra politician Sharad Pawar played a key role in the change of gauge for Delhi Metro, Sreedharan recalls, 'Fortunately, some time after this meeting, a Group of Ministers was appointed, and Pawar became the chairman of the Group of Ministers. I kept fighting my battle and said, "Delhi Phase I is lost,but why should we continue broad gauge for the rest of the country?" I had a discussion with Pawar. He was fully convinced that standard gauge was best. This was after about a year from the meeting when the decision for broad gauge had been taken. Pawar then volunteered to call another meeting.'

'So, another meeting of the Group of Ministers was called, and it was Pawar who pioneered the decision that the Metro Rail should be standard gauge. Pawar had a vision. He said, "Why should the remaining cities suffer?" He saved the day by putting across a clause that the gauge would be decided with the concurrence of the state governments building the Metro Railway, not by the Indian Railways. Then the Metro Act came in and things changed. The railways […] continues to create problems, but this decision by Pawar changed everything, and almost all the state governments went for standard gauge,' he says. [149]

This is the reason the Delhi Metro has two gauges.

A POWER CUT WITH THE PRIME MINISTER ON-BOARD THE INAUGURAL DELHI METRO TRAIN

The first line of the Delhi Metro connecting eastern Delhi's Shahdara to north-central Tis Hazari was ready by 2002. Trials were flagged off by the then Deputy Prime Minister Lal Krishna Advani in September 2002, and Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee threw it open for the public a day before Christmas, on 24 December 2002.

The response was immense, with citizens of Delhi eager to take a ride, and overcrowding causing the ticketing system to collapse. But a lesser-known incident was of a power cut on the Metro network when the Prime